

THE PC OF THE FUTURE

So how does the PC look like, 20 years from now? We peer into the crystal ball.

Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

Prophesying the future of any technology domain has always been a difficult thing to do. Not that we're held back by our limited imagination, but the pace of innovation is so rapid that any reasonable prediction we make always ends up being way too conservative. Since Artificial Intelligence has become very accessible, almost every company with a good R&D division is using AI to build reliable data models and hasten the research process. So take these predictions with a pinch of salt. If at all you are reading this 20 years from when it was written and they all seem way too conservative, you know why.

IS THE PC REALLY DYING?

No, the personal computer is not going to die anytime soon, no matter which form factor we're looking at. From the traditional desktop machine to the new slim ultraportables, the value that a personal computer holds makes it invulnerable for the next 20 years.

However, there has been a strong shift towards smaller and sleeker form factors and manufacturers are more than happy to accommodate customers since it allows them to charge a premium. The older bulkier systems don't give manufacturers as high a margin as they used to, but since they form the bulk of the PC business, it's going to be around till the market share makes it unviable to continue. And even the slim computers aren't going to outlast the traditional desktop by a huge margin. Simply consider them to be a stage on the PC's path of evolution towards becoming commoditised. However, it's this path of evolution that we're curious about, and this is what we think is most likely to happen with PCs.

DISPLAY

Let's start with the most visible component of the PC. There's no questioning the fact that the display and keyboard are what's keeping the PC from shrinking further. Going

below the 13-inch form factor is seen as asking to be ignored by the customer as we can assuage from the shrinking tablet market. Tablets aren't popular and manufacturers aren't going to place their bets on a dying market so we'll continue to see the 13/15/17-inch screens to live on. However, the panel technology should see interesting developments.

Foldable screens should become more popular as it will allow computers to be squeezed into an even smaller dimension. Imagine a notebook that fits in your pocket that can be unfolded twice before you operate it. Provided the elastomers that allow for "bending" can survive repetitive bending. The other interesting development we expect is for haptic displays to become mainstream. Though it will remain a novelty until the haptic feedback can be used to provide a practical and long lasting feature. Another possibility is to use projection technology to provide both, a keyboard and display, thus,